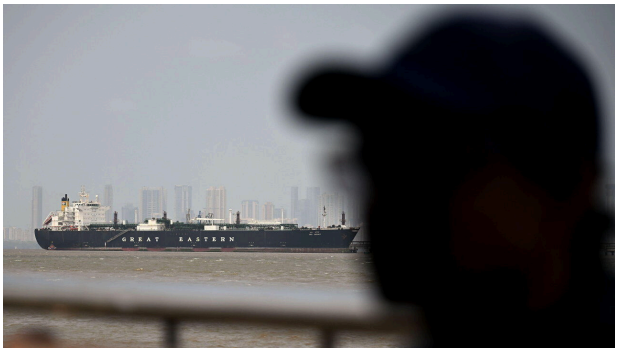
# The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter




Photograph: Alamy

A tanker and container ship in the **Strait of Hormuz** reported coming under fire from Iranian gunboats off the coast of Oman, according to the UK Maritime Trade Organisation, which monitors security at sea. An “unknown projectile” reportedly damaged the second ship’s cargo. Separately, Reuters reported that two merchant vessels said they were hit by gunfire while attempting to cross the strait.

Earlier on Saturday **Iran’s armed forces** had said, via state media, that they were reasserting “strict control” of the strait until America lifted its blockade of Iranian ports. After Iran’s foreign minister declared the waterway “completely open” to commercial shipping on Friday, Donald Trump said that the blockade would stay in place.

Emmanuel Macron, **France’s** president, said that a French member of a UN peacekeeping force had been killed in **Lebanon**, the day after a ceasefire between Israel and Hizbullah began. Mr Macron said evidence suggested that the Iranian-backed militia was responsible for the attack, in which three other soldiers were wounded. Lebanon’s prime minister said he had ordered an investigation.

**India's** ruling Bharatiya Janata Party failed to pass a **constitutional amendment** that would have increased women's representation in parliament and expanded its lower house from 543 seats to about 850. The legislation would have reserved a third of the seats in the enlarged chamber for women. The opposition accused the BJP of using women's representation as a pretext to redraw India's electoral map.

**Spain** and **Brazil** signed 15 agreements—covering critical minerals, telecoms and artificial intelligence—during talks between Pedro Sánchez and Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva in Barcelona. The meeting coincided with a gathering of leaders from Latin America, Africa and Europe hosted by Mr Sánchez. It aimed to strengthen ties among countries pushing back against America's increasingly interventionist foreign policy.

Police in **Dubai** arrested **Daniel Kinahan**, an Irishman alleged to be the leader of one of the world's biggest drug cartels. Mr Kinahan was detained on an Irish arrest warrant and will be charged with various organised-crime offences. The arrest is seen as a sign that the United Arab Emirates is clamping down on European criminal suspects after gaining a reputation as a safe haven for them.

**Japan** is preparing for future heatwaves by giving a new name, *kokushobi*, to days of oppressive heat. The word, chosen after an online survey by the Japan Meteorological Agency, roughly translates as "cruelly hot". Last summer Japan endured its highest temperatures on record, with nine days above 40°C. The agency says the new word will help "effectively call for vigilance" against extreme heat.

**Word of the week:** "Passport bros", Western men who go abroad to find traditional wives. Read about how frustration with modern dating has fuelled the social-media movement.

Photograph: Anadolu via Getty Images

# Hormuz reopening will not end the energy crisis

Iran says the Strait of Hormuz is open again, easing fears of a prolonged energy shock. Oil and gas prices have fallen sharply in response. But the relief may prove premature. The reopening rests on a fragile ceasefire due to expire in days, with key details unresolved—such as which routes tankers may use, whether insurers will cover ships entering a conflict zone and if America will lift its own blockade on Iran-linked vessels. On Saturday Iran's armed forces said they would keep control of the strait until the blockade ended.

Even in the best case, normal flows will take time to resume. Gulf producers must restart output, tankers need to return to the region and refiners must ramp up activity. High insurance costs and security risks may deter shipowners, while damaged infrastructure will slow supply. That leaves markets vulnerable to continued disruption. Prices may stay elevated and volatile, especially if the ceasefire collapses. For now, traders are betting on de-escalation. But until ships move freely and consistently through the strait, the global energy system will remain under strain.

Photograph: Shutterstock

# Turmoil at India’s biggest bank

On Saturday India’s largest private bank, HDFC Bank, reported that net profits in the fourth quarter rose by 9% year on year, to around 192bn rupees ($2bn). The robust results, however, may do little to reassure investors unsettled by recent turmoil at the top of the institution. Last month HDFC’s chairman, Atanu Chakraborty, resigned abruptly, citing differences with colleagues over “values and ethics”. He offered no details, though he is reported to have clashed with the chief executive over strategy and the bank’s handling of complaints that it sold risky bonds to unsuspecting clients.

HDFC denies any governance problems. Earlier this month India’s central bank backed that view, pointing to the lender’s “sound financials”, “professionally run board” and “competent management team”. The endorsement lifted the share price. Even so, confidence remains fragile: the stock is down by about a fifth this year.

Photograph: Getty Images

## Ferrari goes the distance

Ferrari is perhaps the most famous carmaker in the world. But in Formula 1, where it made its reputation, it is not as strong as it once was. The “tifosi”, Ferrari’s fans, have not had a constructors’ championship to cheer since 2008. After a shake-up of the rules, its prospects look brighter this year.

It is in endurance racing, rather than F1, that Ferrari has found most success recently. After a 50-year hiatus it returned to the World Endurance Championship, a series of eight gruelling races, in 2023 with a new, petrol-electric “hypercar”. By 2025 it dominated its class, with teams coming first and third in the championship. The new season begins on Saturday with a six-hour race at Imola, close to Ferrari’s factory in Italy. The omens look good: at final practice this week a Ferrari driver posted the fastest lap. And the circuit is named after Ferrari’s founder, Enzo, and his son Dino.

Photograph: Getty Images

# Weekend profile: Asim Munir, Donald Trump's favourite field-marshal

Descending from his plane onto the Tehran tarmac on April 15th, Asim Munir looked every inch the military strongman. The mustachioed chief of Pakistan's army wore fatigues and a black beret and carried a baton, a symbol of his rank as field-marshal. He greeted Iran's foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, with a salute, followed by a bear hug.

Officially, Field-Marshal Munir has no role in foreign policy. Yet he brokered the temporary ceasefire between Iran and America. On April 11th in Pakistan's capital he hosted the first meeting between delegations from the two countries in almost 50 years. Now he is engineering a second, perhaps this time including Donald Trump, who has called him his "favourite field-marshal". Although Pakistan has a civilian government, Field-Marshal Munir is the country's most powerful person.

Such a career would have seemed improbable back in 2019, when Pakistan's then prime minister, Imran Khan, removed him from the powerful post of spy chief. But after Mr Khan, a cricketer-turned-populist-superstar, was ousted by the political and military establishment, then-General Munir was brought back into the fold. He was appointed army chief in 2022, and quickly secured his grip on the armed forces by locking up rivals.

His making, however, was a four-day war with India last year. The downing of five Indian jets inspired a wave of Pakistani patriotism. General Munir took advantage, getting himself promoted to the armed forces' highest rank (he is the second person ever to reach it) and ramming through constitutional changes to expand his role and extend his tenure. He is now the most powerful Pakistani leader since Pervez Musharraf, a military officer-turned-dictator who was deposed in 2008.

Field-Marshal Munir is the son of an imam, and the first army chief who can recite the Koran by heart. He is secretive, an unsurprising quality in a former leader of the foreign- and military-intelligence agencies. One of the few journalists to have met him reveals only that he has a firm handshake and smokes Dunhill Blue cigarettes. Less mysterious is his vision for Pakistan, which involves military strength, confronting India and the Afghan Taliban, and closer ties with other Muslim powers, from Turkey to Saudi Arabia.

He is sharp, wily, ambitious and ruthless, say those who have watched his rise. But if that has helped to bring success abroad, it has been coupled with deepening repression at home. Mr Khan is in solitary confinement; hundreds more politicians have been jailed and media freedom has been curtailed. "Our generation thought we'd left this behind us," says Mustafa Khokhar, vice-chairman of the opposition alliance. If he achieves more diplomatic success Field-Marshal Munir will become even more powerful at home.

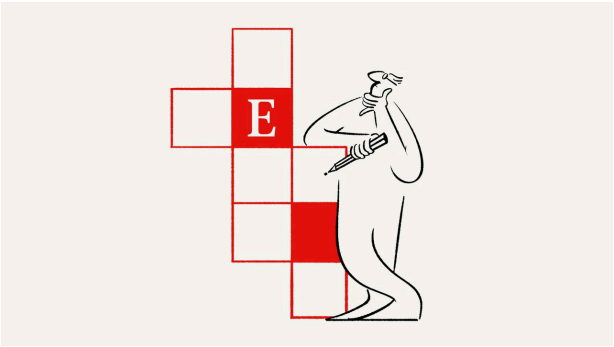



Illustration: The Economist

# Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here. Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

## Cryptic clues

*1 across* - Stormont sides with global conflict (6)

*2 across* - Explosive noble prize-giver (5)

*3 across* - Kevin or Malcolm have ordinary feature (6)

*1 down* - What learners owe after graduation stunned a lot (7,4)

## Straight clues

*1 across* - Discord, argument (6)

*2 across* - Inventor of dynamite and founder of coveted prizes (5)

*3 across* - Usual, conventional (6)

*4 across* - Money borrowed to pay for university (7,4)

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

# The winners of the week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

**Jeff Schock**, Olympia, Washington, America
**John Biggs**, Sheffield, Britain
**Luis Llanos**, Santiago, Chile

They all gave the correct answers of: Ken Burns, Flanders, Maggie Gyllenhaal, the Mona Lisa and Homer. The theme is characters from "The Simpsons": Mr Burns, Ned Flanders, Maggie, Lisa and Homer Simpson.

The questions were:

**Monday**: Which American film-maker is known for documentary series on the US civil war, baseball and the Vietnam war?

**Tuesday**: Brussels is the capital of which region in Belgium?

**Wednesday**: Which American actress and film-maker directed the 2026 movie "The Bride!"?

**Thursday**: Which famous painting was stolen from the Louvre in 1911 and not returned until 1914?

**Friday**: Which Greek poet is generally credited as the writer of the Iliad and the Odyssey?

*The greatest deception men suffer is from their own opinions*

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***Leonardo da Vinci***